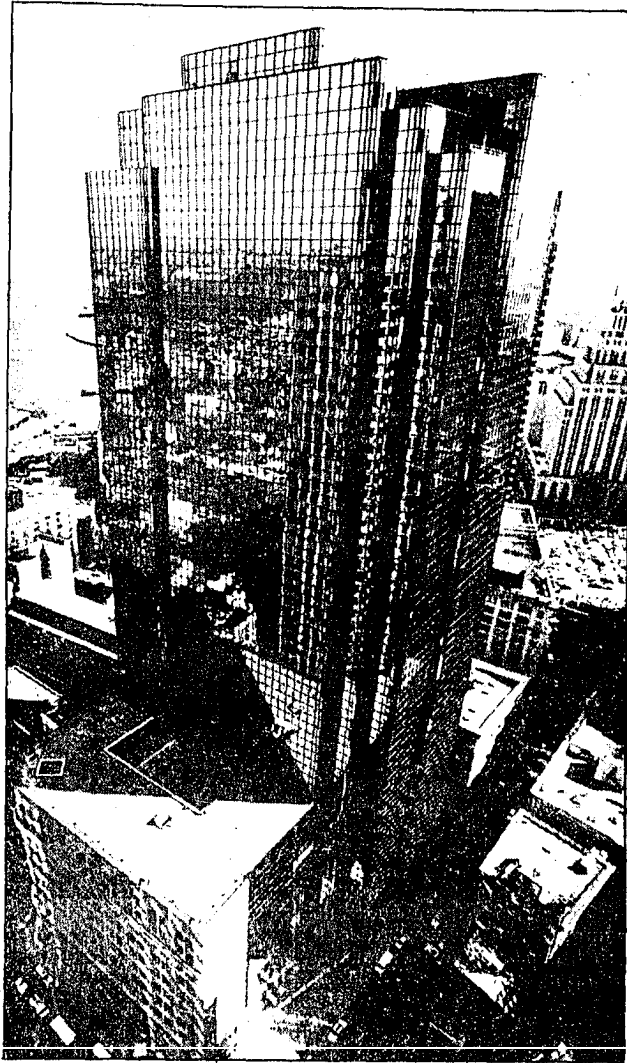
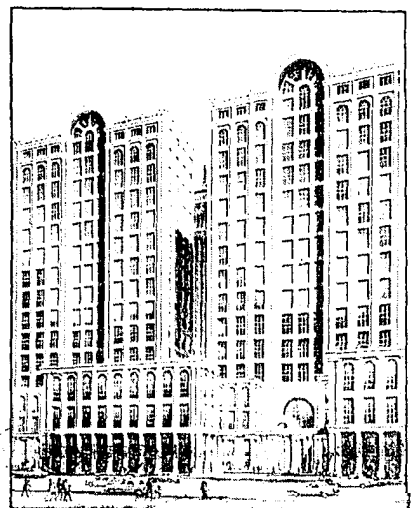




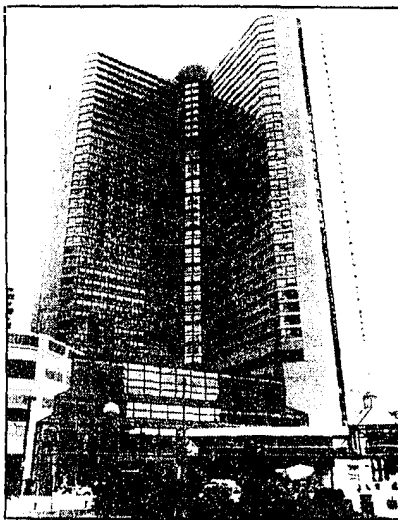
■ Exchange Place on State street at Congress street.



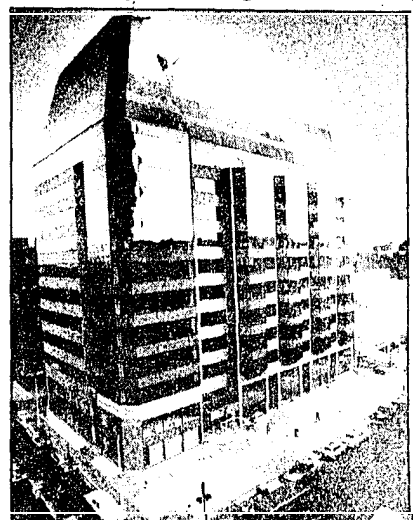
■ Lafayette Place.



■ Rendering for New England Life building.



■ The Marriott at Copley Place.



■ Exeter Place.

BOSTON'S WORST BUILDINGS

By Robert Campbell
 Globe Correspondent

There are plenty of awards given for beautiful and appropriate works of architecture. This is as it should be. Yet, I've always wondered whether the public wouldn't be better served by an annual award to the ugliest and most life-degrading buildings of the year. Such a list would be one on which, I imagine, no one would want his or her building to be included, and thus it might be a deterrent to bad architecture as strong as the other kind of award is an inducement to good architecture.

It's with that thought in mind that I hereby inaugurate the annual Pru Award, to be given each year to the most awful buildings in Boston and eastern New England.

First of all, though, a word about the award's name. It hasn't been chosen whimsically. For the past eight years, I've taught a course about architecture at a local university, a course for people who have an interest in buildings but

Presenting the Pru Award, to be given each year to the most awful architecture around

who aren't themselves architects. Each semester, I poll my classes by asking each member to list his or her best-liked and least-liked buildings in the Boston area. Every single class, spring and fall, without exception, has voted the Prudential Tower its least-liked building.

If there had been an Ugly Building Award in Boston during the past generation, there can be no doubt that the Pru would have retired it. That being so, it is fitting that we honor a building so unanimously deplored by naming this award after it. And since the Pru is now a venerable quarter-century, old, no one need be offended. So let it be the Pru Award for Bad Buildings.

The purpose of the Pru Award isn't to embarrass architects. Very often the

true author of a bad building isn't the architect at all. The architect may be so trapped by an insensitive client or an impossible budget that good work becomes impossible. The public and the city government, too, may bear much of the blame. If we don't demand good architecture, we don't deserve it, and we won't get it.

I've limited the Pru Awards to current buildings - proposed, under construction or recently finished. It's a shame, of course, not to be able to Pruminate some of the classic New England architectural and planning blunders of recent years - the unforgettably banal pedestrian mall in Laconia, N.H., for instance, or the insanely misconceived library tower at UMass-Amherst, or the telephone company building (any telephone company building, it doesn't

matter), or such ungainly downtown Boston towers as the Bank of Boston and One Boston Place and the Fidelity Trust. It would be nice to recall all the way back to the Pru's own generation to give overdue recognition to the appalling Charles River Park. William James Hall at Harvard would, at a smaller scale, surely do honor to the Pru Award. So would the JFK Federal Building. So would ... but I must stop. The historians will have to deal with the past. The Pru Award is for the present.

Here, then, are the winners of the 1984 Pru Award for Bad Buildings (in no particular order):

Exeter Place. Boylston and Exeter streets. Architect Jung/Brannen Associates. Owner, Boylston Partners.

I can't remember hearing so many outraged comments made about any Boston building since the Pru itself. They're well deserved. Exeter Place is a WORST, Page A2

Boston's worst buildings

■ WORST
Continued from Page A1

malformed, tacky attempt to make a 14-story office building look like a Victorian townhouse with a mansard roof and bay windows. The attempt is carried out with so little finesse that the result has the tragic look of those misplaced people who inhabit the photographs of Diane Arbus. Not only doesn't it belong in the Back Bay, it doesn't belong anywhere, except in our nightmares. Unfortunately, it won't be in our dreams, but in the bright light of our days for the next generation or more.

It's hard to define just what it is that makes Exeter Place so implacably grim. Partly it's the colors: gloomy seaweed-green glass set against orange-brown brick. Partly it's the thinness of everything, the sense you get that this building has been made entirely of plastic-wrap only one molecule thick. At heart, though, the problem is one of scale. Nothing is quite the right size. Exeter Place is ugly for the same reason the duckling was: It's overgrown and out of proportion with itself and everything around it. It appears to be a parody.

There's sad irony, incidentally, in the fact that at the other end of the very same block now being trashed by Exeter Place stands what is probably the best lesson Boston has ever been given on the subject of fitting a large building into a streetscape of small townhouses: the New Old South Church of 1875 by Cummings and Sears.

Lafayette Place. Washington street. Architecture: Mitchell/Giurgola Architects, Philadelphia. Owner: Mondev International, Montreal.

We don't seem to build buildings anymore, we build Places. Lafayette Place, the new shopping/hotel complex next to Jordan Marsh, is a bold architectural bid to outdo Copley Place in the sheer boring blankness of the face it turns to the street. As at Copley Place, the idea here seems to be that the street is a dangerous and dirty place where you can only expect to get your pocket picked and your body violated. How much better, then, to leave the nasty city altogether and pass through the nearly windowless walls of this forbidding gray fortress into a safe suburban haven of brightly lighted jeans shops and hamburger stands.

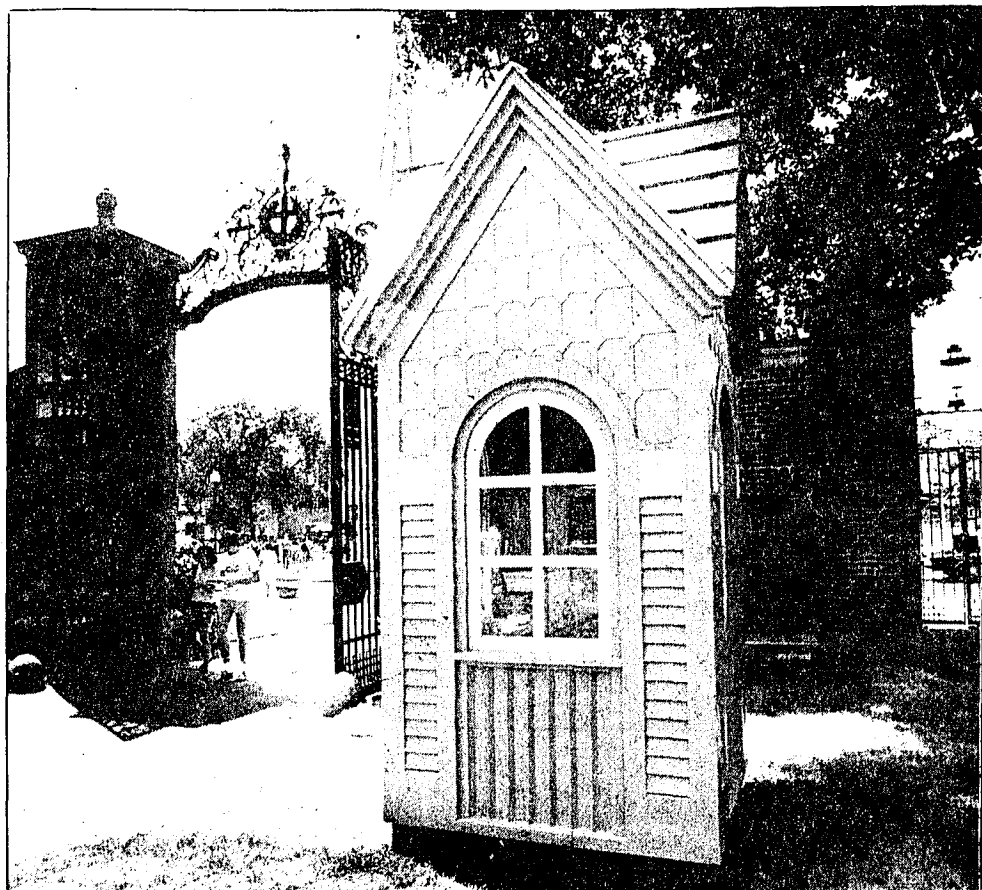
Lafayette Place is far from complete, and it would be unfair to comment in detail on its interior. The hotel tower is still empty, and so are half the stores. Some of the Lafayette Place's ideas are promising, such as the arrangement of shopping and eating in a huge circle overlooking a round courtyard that is punctuated by the hotel.

But for the exterior, there can be no excuse. Good cities are made of lively streets, not of interiors hidden behind cliffs of gray brick. Only the most token attempt is made here to relieve the seemingly endless gray exterior by means of a few darker bricks, a few tiny spots of red and a few back doors to shops. Boston's indigenous architecture developed its rich surfaces of red brick because our Januaries are gray enough already. More gray we don't require. Lafayette Place is a dead whale, belly-up, on Boston's most vital retail street.

New England Life Addition. Boylston street between Clarendon and Berkley. Architect: John Burgee Architects with Philip Johnson. Owner: New England Mutual Life Insurance Company and Gerald Hines Interests.

The problem here is a building that aspires — successfully, unfortunately — to a level of grandeur that's entirely inappropriate to its setting and its use. Burgee and Johnson have ransacked the architectural history books for the kind of detail that once expressed the power of kings and dukes and now is perverted to express that of corporations. Their building's suburban impact is as bad as its detail: At its rear, it looms as high as the old John Hancock Tower directly across St. James street, a relationship that promises to create Boston's darkest dreariest street. New England Life is an arrogant palace that has no place in the Back Bay.

The problems could be solved by rearranging the building's masses into a less imposing pile and mitigating such overscaled elements as the typical two-story windows. Saving the lovely, quirky Coulton Building at the corner of Berkley would also help take the curse of hugeness and sameness off this vast superblock. Closing the opening into its sun-



The Harvard Yard Guardhouse looks as out of place as a lunar landing module.

less courtyards would help, too. This building deserves its Pru for precisely the reason that nobody involved in it to date has shown any serious inclination to respond to the mounting criticism.

Harvard Yard Guardhouse. Harvard Yard. Architect: Graham Gund Associates. Owner: Harvard University.

The talent of one of Boston's more inventive architectural firms, and the unfathomable decision-making process of one of our most erratic architectural clients, have combined to create a masterpiece of kitsch in this tiny but unforgettably inept building, the costliest structure, at more than \$1000 per square foot of floor area, ever built in these parts. The guardhouse is an inexplicable exercise in the Queen Anne style that is painted a most un-Queen-Anne-like cosmetic pink, as if its creators had panicked at the sight of their creation and tried to hide it under acne cream. It relates to nothing around it in style, materials or scale and would look about equally at home in Harvard Yard if it were a lunar landing module.

Exchange Place. State street at Congress street. Architect: WZMH Group. Owner: Olympia & York, Toronto.

Exchange Place has a certain shapely glitter, if you keep your eye firmly on its skyline profile. But it's a glitter that's skin deep, and only serves to make the older buildings around Exchange Place seem shabbier than they are. The entire building appears to have only one detail, a squarish, black-trimmed piece of glass that is repeated a zillion times. Even the structural columns are covered in this glass grid, like the scaly legs of dinosaurs. Dead at the street, grandiose at the entry, overbearing in its relation to what is left of the old Stock Exchange Building, most of which was demolished to make way for it, Exchange Place is big, shiny and un-Bostonian, the expression of an era in which Boston developers seemed bent on emulating the tinsel towers of Houston.

Marriott Hotel at Copley Place. Huntington avenue. Architect: Stubbins Associates. Owner: Urban Investment and Development Corporation and Marriott Hotels.

There's no need to say much in justification of this Pru Award except that like most convention hotels of our era, the Marriott is a totally disorienting sprawl of angular spaces that zig and zag incomprehensibly through and around a vast glassy atrium. It is impossible to find your way around or to tell whether you are in Boston or Singapore. No cliché is left untapped: the vines draped over the parapets are the same all over the world. My brain vaporizes instantly in places like the Marriott, and I suspect that this effect is, in fact, the design objective.

One Financial Center. Dewey Square. Architect: Pietro Belluschi and Jung/Brannen Associates. Owner: Rose Associates and Metropolitan Life Insurance Company.

Another so-called "Place." How do the letter-carriers find them? Whatever happened to street addresses?

Mental health authorities should place a final and ultimate ban on precast concrete skin panels for all high-rise buildings. One Financial Center carries the crime of precasting to new levels with a skin that lacks color, texture and scale. The building's appearance